

New Year

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Ahem, my friends. Yes, my dearest and strangest friends. How funny it is to stand before you now, to look upon faces that have shared in many wanderings.

When I think of our times, both brief and long, the road seems impossibly twisting, like an old river that has carved itself through stone, bending and coiling and doubling back until you no longer know whether you walk towards some bright horizon or merely retrace your own lost footprints. Yet on we go, for that is the way with folks such as us. We walk the paths of places half-remembered by the world, forsaken by time and mortal memory.

We have seen dawn rise over the rolling old earth hills, where the grass sways like the beards of ancient kings. We have drifted through the void, where dragons hunt within an onyx ocean, their slow wings stirring currents of terror. We have found respite in places of hidden marvel.

Pappy's hot springs, warm as the breath of the world's deep heart, found wonder in Vyseith's tomb with its sorrow-laden stones. And Xerathis, yes, Xerathis itself, the city that defies the gods, defiant as the dawn. But no less wondrous than the lands we hath crossed are the people who walked them with us.

Truly we are an eclectic company, a tapestry woven from threads so unlike one another that no loom should have held them. And yet, you are. There is Wren, the Shadarchi huntress, sharp-eyed, sharp-voiced, and sharp-souled, forever watchful, forever aflame with that fierce, restless spirit the shadows danced with.

And Saint Anki, ah, Anki, who lives as though each morning is a prank played upon the heavens themselves, a little drunk, a little holy, a little mad, but all heart. And dear Cecil, poor Cecil, our gentle turtle, he watched the world with patient eyes, and in every vine, in every leaf, he found something to love until his time came. May he rest amongst the flowers and fields of a better world.

These are only a few among many, yet thinking of them I find myself overwhelmed by the breadth of what we have done together. For we have fought battles, heavens above have we fought battles. The assault on Wrath, when the very stone seemed ready to melt with fury.

The grim defense against Ionia, goddess of time, where bodies and hearts were broken by the task at hand. And the slaying of the summoned Tiamat, that dread five-fold tyrant whose shadow darkened the world itself. Yet we are not merely breakers of things, we are binders too.

You have broken peace with the Rahu, whose ways were once closed to all outsiders. You have tended the wounded and the weary in Eovar, gathering the sick into your arms as though they were long lost kin. You raised the walls of Pristina stone by stone, even when the city offered little

gratitude.

Yet build as you did, for you knew it must be done. And between battles and burdens you found room, somehow impossibly, for festivals and merrymaking, for setting down laws and lifting up laughter, weaving joy into the world even as sorrow pressed in at the edges. And what marriages we have celebrated along the way.

The noble Dale, steadfast in oath and spirit, bound to the clever quick-minded Sorey, appearing as natural as day and dusk. And who could forget the union of Edelia, shadow-clad and mysterious as midnight stars, with Jiangshi, loving and wise, a lantern that refused to dim even when the night grew long. Still, even these are but a handful of the stories that cling to us like the scent of old fire.

I remember Swiftfoot, whose sacrifice was so noble and selfless indeed, that only after the dust settled did we truly grasp its power. I think of Elenia, cleaved in two by wrath, the brightest light snuffed in an instant, and yet Gartina called out and that light rekindled. And speaking of Gartina who could fail to smile at the strange and tender romance of Gartina and Draegar.

Little Gartina, our halfling chef, barely taller than a well-shaped loaf, and Draegar, mighty warrior, a walking avalanche of sinew and steel. Through all this, through triumph and terror, through love and war, you have done more than simply oppose death, ender of all good things, patient hunter of every life. You have breathed life back into a world that had begun to dim, like a flickering candle at the end of its wick.

You have spoken hope into the ears of the hopeless. You have kindled lights where none remained, and where the light refused to kindle, you carried the flame yourselves. So here we stand, at the edge of yet another chapter.

The road stretches on, curling ahead in ways unseen, perhaps dire, perhaps glorious. But I look upon you, all of you, and I know this. Whatever shadows rise, whatever storms gather, together as we always have.

For we are wanderers, and warriors, and healers, and makers of merry noise. We are lovers, builders, and breakers of chains. We are the strange, stubborn hope of a world that has nearly forgotten how to hope.

And by all stars above us, and all the dust beneath our feet, we will endure.

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